

"Companies, today, cannot escape from the magic of open source technology"

Open source technology has become a need, more than a choice for any company, opines **Sridhar Sarathy, vice president, India Operations, India Excellence Center, Juniper Networks**. This is the reason why demand for open source professionals is increasing in a big way. **Diksha P Gupta** from **Open Source For You** magazine spoke to Sarathy about how Juniper hires in India. Excerpts:



Q How do you recruit engineering talent at Juniper Networks, and do you also recruit open source professionals?

Juniper operates in the high-performance networking space. We do products that are in routing, switching and security for the networking industry. Worldwide, we are only 9000 employees and the India centre has about 2400 employees. All our products are based on an operating system called 'Junos', which has about 27 million lines of code. It is based on FreeBSD, so it is an open source-based technology. BSD UNIX and C are the two tools on which the operating system is based. So yes, we do hire open source professionals, but what we need are people with a background in open source technology backed by experience in the networking domain.

We primarily hire two kinds of people: one is people with experience and a strong tech background for the development of next-gen architects, and the other is fresh hires. We hire

from colleges in two ways. We have an internship programme wherein students in their final semester in colleges go through our selection process and spend six months with us working on live projects. By 'live project' I mean that they work as a part of the project team, taking part in design meetings, interacting with the international teams, play an active part in lab reviews, and so on. We go to colleges in September-October and interview students. We select about 50 students who spend six months from January-July at Juniper. At the end of the six months, depending on how they liked working in Juniper and how we liked their performance, around 65 per cent of those who interned with us, join us. In addition, we also do fresh graduate hiring in certain colleges, which is not part of the internship program.

So we do hiring from colleges and we also hire experienced people.

Q How much can open source tools help organisations both financially and technically?

Interoperability between products (from different companies and vendors) is one of the key areas of our focus and open source technology lets us do that pretty well. So we are big fans of interoperability and open source. From a technical viewpoint, I don't think one has a choice but to go this way. I think companies always have a bias towards hiring someone who comes with an open source background. At this point in time, I don't think most companies worry about the financial aspect of things. I think they care more about the fact that they need to have products that are interoperable with others. And I can confidently say that interoperability is a lot easier to attain with open source tools than with proprietary software. I think it definitely helps from the financial viewpoint, but most people look at the technical viability it brings along.

Q What skillsets do you look for in open source professionals when you hire at Juniper?

When we go to hire someone from a college, we cannot expect them to have experience in the domain. So, in these cases we look at whether the candidates have a course background, whether they have done programming on some good projects that will enable them, and whether they are capable of picking up new things as we go along. Those are the kind of people we